join the emperor's cult, he had become one of his most valued friends and advisers, so much so that Akbar said he would have given all his treasure to ransom Fathullah, and considered 'that precious jewel [bought] cheap'.[30]

Akbar was on his way back from Kashmir, still mourning his friend's passing, when Hakim Abul Fath – finally forgiven his failure to protect Birbar – fell ill with violent diarrhoea. The camp came to a halt, doctors were called, but the hakim died.

Only three months later, in November 1589, Akbar suffered another dual loss when Todar Mal and Bhagwant Das died within days of each other.

Todar Mal had written to Akbar two months earlier, requesting retirement; he wanted, he said, to spend his 'old age and sickness' by the Ganga 'remembering God'.[31] Akbar agreed, then quickly rescinded his decision. It was Todar Mal who had chased after Sultan Daud with Munim Khan; Todar Mal ('upon whose tactics, bravery, and loyalty the army depended'[32]) who fought the Bengal rebels with Aziz and Shahbaz Khan. It was Todar Mal, too, who had managed so much of Akbar's agricultural and revenue reform – with enough success, evidently, to merit celebratory elegies from an aggrieved nobility. Badauni records an anonymous wit who wrote, 'Todar Mal was he, whose tyranny had oppressed the world, / When he went to Hell, people became merry.'[33] A court poet from Orchha, Keshava Das, recipient of Birbar's patronage, composed a similarly disparaging assessment of Todar Mal versus his patron: '*Todarmal tum mitra mare, sab hi sukh socho / More hit Varvir bina, tuk deenani rocho*' (Todarmal died, everyone slept peacefully / But in the absence of my friend Birbal, the poverty-stricken wept bitterly).[34]

Akbar needed Todar Mal, the man who had so long combined his military and administrative genius towards the expansion and management of the realm, so he wrote to him that 'no worship of God was equal to the soothing of the oppressed', and asked him to withdraw his resignation.[35]

Todar Mal had already set out for Haridwar when Akbar's message arrived. Dutifully, he returned to Lahore, where he died on 8 November. Bhagwant Das was among those at Todar Mal's funeral, and fell ill upon his return. He, too, was gone by the 14th of the month.

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